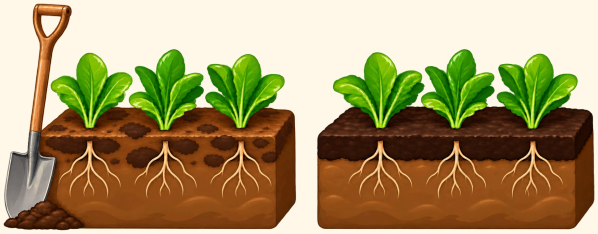
Dig or No–Dig

Choosing your approach

Both methods can grow a good crop. The useful question is which suits your ground, your compost supply and the amount of work you can manage. You can change your mind as the garden develops.



Digging

Turn soil and mix in compost.

No–dig

Leave soil intact; compost on top.

What are the trade–offs?

Topic	Dig pro	Dig con	No-dig pro	No-dig con
Overview	Loosens soil; exposes buried debris.	Hard physical work.	No need to turn the ground.	Compost still needs shifting.
Weeds	Lets you remove weed roots.	Brings buried weed seeds up.	Mulch smothers many weeds.	Persistent weeds need follow-up.
Compost	Can start with less compost.	Still needs organic matter over time.	Feeds soil from the surface.	New beds need plenty of compost.
Tools	Uses familiar hand tools.	Requires a spade or fork.	Permanent bed sides are optional.	Cardboard for a new weedy bed.
Soil	Can relieve compaction.	Cannot fix every drainage problem.	Leaves soil structure intact.	Does not cure every wet site.
Later years	Can switch to no-dig later.	Repeated digging disturbs soil life.	No annual turning of the soil.	Still weed, water and top up compost.

You needn't join a camp

My own beds have taken both routes: digging first and changing to no-dig, or starting over lawn. Choose for your plot. In either system, work from paths to avoid treading the beds.

Getting started with No-Dig

Here we are starting a small bed over grass or ordinary weeds. On an existing weed-free bed, you can leave out the cardboard and add compost straight to the surface.

You need: Plain brown cardboard, well-rotted compost, rake, watering can and a trowel. A barrow saves carrying.



1

Cover the ground

Mark out a bed you can reach from the paths. Remove tape and staples from plain cardboard, then overlap the sheets generously so light cannot get through the joins. Wet dry cardboard to help it lie flat. Clear woody growth and rubbish first.

2

Add the compost

Spread about 4 inches of well-rotted compost over the cardboard. Break up lumps, remove woody pieces and firm gently with the back of a rake. Leave the soil underneath alone. Timber sides are optional; sloping edges will do.

3

Start growing

You can plant straight into the finished layer when the season suits your crop. For small seeds, use a little finer compost in the drill. Follow the crop's guide for depth and spacing, and water in. Keep an eye out for weeds pushing through.

Keep it going

Add roughly 1–2 inches of compost each year when the bed is free. Pull small weeds promptly, stop grass creeping in at the edges and water when needed. No-dig saves turning the soil; it doesn't do the rest of the gardening for you.

Watch out for

Persistent weeds may need repeated clearing or longer under cover. Fresh plant waste shelters slugs; use well-rotted compost. Investigate persistent waterlogging before you start.

Getting started with Digging

Single digging turns the topsoil. Double digging also loosens the layer underneath: a bigger job for a new or compacted bed, done at the start or occasionally, rather than every year.

Single digging: the annual job

On an established dug bed, spread well-rotted compost or manure where needed. Start at one edge and turn the ground over with a spade or fork, working backwards so you don't tread on what you have loosened. Work to one spade's depth, bury the compost, break large clods and remove stones and weed roots. There is no need to organise this into trenches.

Double digging: work in trenches

You need: A strong fork, digging spade, rake, barrow and well-rotted compost or manure.



1

Open the first trench

Clear weeds and mark out the bed. Spread half your compost over it; keep the rest beside you. Dig across one end, one spade wide and deep. Save this topsoil in a barrow or at the far end for the final trench.

2

Loosen underneath

Add a couple of spadefuls of compost to the trench bottom. Fork the lower soil another full fork-depth, mixing it in and removing rubble. Take small bites; use a mattock on hard patches. Loosen the subsoil in place, keeping it beneath the topsoil.

3

Move along the bed

Dig the next trench alongside, turning its topsoil into the first and mixing in the surface compost. Break clods and remove weed roots. Now add compost and fork the bottom of this new trench, just as before. Repeat along the bed.

Work when soil crumbles. If it is wet and sticky or frozen, wait. Take small bites and regular breaks.

Finish the bed on the next page.

Digging continued

4

Fill the final gap

Loosen the bottom of the last trench with compost, then fill it with the topsoil you saved at the start. Fork any remaining compost into the surface. Rake the top level and slope the sides; timber edging is optional.

5

Settle and plant

Let the loosened soil settle. For small seeds, rake the surface into fine crumbs. Follow the crop's guide for planting time, depth and spacing, then water in. If the bed must wait, cover it with a tarp; remove the cover and any slugs before planting.

Keep your feet on the paths

Permanent paths help prevent the bed being compacted again. Single digging is the usual yearly routine in a dug garden; reserve double digging for when the deeper soil needs loosening. You can switch to surface compost and no-dig as the bed improves.

Another option: Smothering

Dig or no-dig, your life becomes easier on overgrown ground if you kill the overgrowth first. Smothering does this by excluding light: cover the patch with an opaque tarpaulin, let the growth die back, then remove the cover and clear the remains.



1

Cut back and cover

Cut tall growth and rake away the cuttings. Lever out bramble crowns and woody roots. Lay an opaque tarpaulin close to the ground, covering the whole patch. Weight its edges with bricks or stones so wind cannot lift it.

2

Give it time

Allow around eight weeks in late spring or summer, or five months or more from late autumn or winter. Check underneath: if growth is still alive, leave it covered longer. Persistent weeds can take more time.

3

Lift and clear

Remove the tarp. Rake or fork out dead growth, shake off the soil and compost the debris. Lift surviving perennial weeds with their roots intact; don't chop them up. Then dig the bed or add compost for no-dig.

John's Hackriculture manuscript and videos; RHS and Charles Dowding. Full sources accompany this draft. Diagrams are schematic.